



BHASKAR PAUL



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WILL ANYONE MAKE ANY MONEY IN SEASON 2?

How could you if you've been rendered homeless? You could just as well call the event the International Premier League. Thanks to the economic slowdown and legal disputes surrounding the IPL, some of the team franchisees have lost their jerseys and title sponsors, not to mention their home grounds. The IPL totted up revenues of nearly \$300 million last year but now sponsors and advertisers question its efficiency.

With the move to South Africa, sponsors are at the deep end as all brand activation at the ground level and post-match interaction with teams will be nearly impossible. Most sponsors of the teams typically get to interact with the players, throw parties and get tickets and ground advertising spots during home matches. Explains Pawan Munjal, MD and CEO of Hero Honda Motors: "The IPL moving out of India is likely to restrict opportunities to leverage our brand association. With this year's edi-



"We will certainly miss playing in front of our supporters. Wherever we play, we hope to have the same fervour that we had last season."

SACHIN TENDULKAR,
Mumbai Indians

tion moving out of the country, it is obviously not going to be the same."

Sponsors will not be able to give tickets to their dealers nor will they be able to undertake brand activations on the ground. Adds Vineet Taneja, marketing director of Nokia India, which has sponsored the Kolkata Knight Riders: "We will realign our on-ground promotions in keeping with the change in the IPL venue." There clearly aren't that many people willing to write out cheques.

Sponsors in Season 2 are almost an endangered species in a property where title sponsorships come for as much as Rs 12-15 crore. In the current environment though, they are being re-negotiated to levels of Rs 8 crore. Says Anirban Das Blah, CEO of sports marketing firm, Globosport: "In the current environment, Rs 16 crore for a title sponsorship will sound absurd as it's going to be a televised event."

A marketing firm working with IPL squads said that at least three teams did not have any title sponsors. Nike, a key apparel sponsor, has decided to focus on Team India and Pepsi is not the official beverage partner of the entire League this year, opting for the smaller peg of partnering the Mumbai Indians and Chennai